

TARN SCENE

“You won’t remember... Come to Luna—*garbled*—system... One day—*garbled*—try to understand.” Bright, flashing lights bleed through an out-of-focus lens.

We cut to an overhead shot of a sleeping brenneri, her head resting on a fluffy pink pillow with white blankets draped over the rest of her body. She wakes with a start. “Sobok?” There’s a mist in her eyes she doesn’t notice.

The room around her is filled with the ordinary belongings of a teenage girl. A small desk sits in the corner, mostly hidden behind a bookshelf from anyone looking in through the main doorway. Tarn’s eyes dart around the room, but the usual flood of sensations that accompanies the morning is gone: no smell of pancakes topped with Ossian cream, no traditional Third Wall ballads playing somewhere beyond her room to lull her from rest. Instead, there is only the cold of band 2.

Knock. Knock. “Little boe, could Mom and I see you in the main hab?” Her father’s voice slips through the door, but it never opens. A moment later, she hears his footsteps receding down the hall.

We cut to the other side of the door a short while later. The metal slides along its rail and disappears into the wall to our left, revealing Tarn dressed for the day with her headphones pulled down from her ears and resting around her neck. “Mom? Dad? Where’s Sobok?”

Her mother stands beside her father in the main hab and motions Tarn closer. “Tarn, sweetie, please. There are a few things we have to tell you.” Tarn sits on the couch while her parents take the ottoman across from her. As they begin to speak, their voices bleed into noise, and the events of the previous night come reeling back.

It had been an uneventful 8th band. Tarn sat on the couch watching reruns of old shows from late Lapse 28 on the plasma holo while Sobok worked diligently in the cook hab. After a while, he emerged wearing a simple garment beneath an apron dusted with flour and specks of other baking ingredients, with a hover-tray following behind him.

“Happy birthday, little boe, happy birthday, little boe, happy birthday, my darling, happy birthday to you.” Sobok sang with a cheery grin as he guided the tray in front of him, presenting a three-tiered cake covered in sparklers. The number **16** stood on top, tipped with flame.

“Sobok, you remembered!” Tarn stared excitedly at the buttery-sweet cake. “This is why you wouldn’t let me go to the store with you band 4!”

Sobok glanced side to side before pulling up a holo-text. “Snooping around Concondonance Hall, I was reading this ancient textbook called *The Birthday Book* by some historian named Todd Parr, and I transferred the contents for you.” He tossed the text-projector to Tarn. “I discovered it was an ancient tradition of the

people on Wander to make a wish on their birthday, and if they blew out all the candles... then it would come true!”

Sobok looked expectantly at Tarn. “Come on. Try it!” Tarn skimmed the scrolling holo-text, then looked back at the cake. “Bththh—” She blew as hard as she could until every candle went dark, and the two of them laughed.

Time offset. Later, as Tarn devised a strategy for attacking what remained of her slice of cake, Sobok sat beside her but stared off into the distance, unable to make eye contact. “You’re all grown up now, ya know? I was only a little older than you when...” He stopped for a moment. “We’ve talked a lot about this place, the things that happen here, but I need you to know that’s little-kid stuff. You won’t be able to think like that anymore.”

Tarn looked over at him. “What are you talking about, dedushka?” Sobok hesitated before answering. “I... I just think maybe I haven’t been the best influence on you. When you’re all grown up, you can’t dream like I do, like I taught you to. You have to let all that go.”

“Sobok, it’s not little-kid stuff. And I’m not eight anymore!” Tarn’s frustration rose with each word. “You told me I was big enough to handle all this!”

Sobok’s face flashed with grief, but when he answered, his voice came out angry. “Well, I was wrong!” Silence followed, and neither of them seemed to know what to say next.

“Sweetheart, are you listening?” Back in the present, Tarn’s mother places a hand on her daughter’s leg. “We need to make sure you understand. You can’t see Sobok anymore.”

Tarn’s father leans forward. “And... and the company has asked us to move, little boe. We can’t stay here anymore, now that... well, now that everything has happened.” He brings up a listing and turns the display toward Tarn. Pictures of a bright housing unit in Crown’s upper frame fill the screen: clean walls, larger rooms, newer appliances, and a wide plasma holo built into the main hab. “But in return for our period of service, we’ve been offered a really wonderful home in the upper frame of Crown—”

Her mother takes over before he can finish. “We have an excellent opportunity. We could get you better schooling during your off semesters.” Tarn looks up from the display. “My off semesters?”

Her father swipes through another photograph, bringing up a clean bedroom. “You know that water leak in your room? That could be a new plasma holo instead.” Another swipe leaves the glossy pictures of the new housing unit beside an older photograph of Tarn’s current room: the stained section of wall near the leak, the cramped furniture, the shelf pushed awkwardly against her desk.

Her mother continues, “Well... sweetheart, for a housing unit like this, the household needs three employments on record.” She pauses and looks toward Tarn’s father. “And seeing as how it’s just the three of us now...”

“I talked with Andrew, and there’s this wonderful—” her mother begins. “—and safe—” Tarn’s father adds quickly. Her mother nods and continues, “—and safe service with openings right now. You’d still be able to attend school when you’re off duty.”

Her father leans forward again, trying to sound encouraging. “This would be a real résumé builder, Tarn. Not many brenneri get service experience this early in their career. And no one would question it given our--” he begins to motion between the three of them but Tarn's mother cuts him off adding, “You’d be helping people, darling. Just... think on it.”

Tarn stares at the housing pictures for another moment before looking from her mother to her father. “What are you asking me to do?”

Her father answers.

“We need you to enlist, little boe.”

The camera cuts to black.